Britain & Ireland Highlights

Welcome & Tour Tips

Britain and Ireland Highlights covers a lot of ground. These notes are here to help you feel ready before we set off, so you can focus on enjoying the journey.

Not everything here will be new to you — think of this as a quick refresher before travelling. Use the navigation below to jump to any section.

This is a personal guide from your Travel Director to help you prepare. For official details, timings, and inclusions, please refer to your Trafalgar documents.

At a glance

📍 **Know where to be**
Your welcome email confirms your departure hotel and departure time from London.

💼 **Check your luggage**
Label your main suitcase clearly before you leave home, and keep your day bag essentials easy to reach.

📱 **Save my number**
Add me to your contacts before you travel — details are in your welcome email or use the links on this page.

📍 London start

Our departure from London is the first time we are all together as a group. Your welcome email confirms the timings and meeting point that apply to your booking.

🕐 Departure from London (morning)

You may have slightly different joining instructions depending on your booking, so please read your welcome email carefully and make sure you are familiar with the timings.

Before coming down, have breakfast, know what is happening with your luggage, and keep your day essentials ready so departure feels smooth. It also helps to use the WC/restroom before boarding.

🚌 Boarding the coach

The reception area can be busy on departure morning. You may see luggage being loaded and people gathering near the coach.

If you prefer to wait by the coach instead of in reception, that is absolutely fine. The key thing is to board Joel's coach at the instructed time.

💼 **Pre-night and porterage:** Some travellers may have a Trafalgar pre-night package with porterage on departure morning, while others may have pre-nights booked independently, sometimes at a different hotel. If you are unsure what applies to your booking for our London start, check your welcome email and joining documents.

📝 Before you travel

This tour departs from London in the morning. A quick check of your joining details before travel usually makes the start feel much smoother.

✅ Check your joining details

Your welcome email and official documents confirm your London meeting hotel and departure time from London. Keep those details easy to access in case you need them.

✈️ Arrival plan

- Before travel day, check your latest airline updates.
- Confirm how you are getting to the London hotel.
- If you have booked a private transfer through Trafalgar, those details are listed separately in your joining documents.
- If your arrival time changes for a pre-booked transfer through Trafalgar, contact European Guest Services (EGS): +44 207 620 8900 / EuropeanGuestServices@ttc.com.
- If you are not using a transfer, official London Black Cabs are safe and easy to find, and apps such as Uber can be used at London airports.

🛄 Keep essentials accessible

Have your passport, wallet, phone, charger and any medications easy to reach rather than buried in your suitcase.

🚌 On the coach

The coach will be our moving base between destinations. A few simple habits help keep things comfortable, safe and pleasant for everyone travelling together.

- 🔁 **Seat rotation** happens daily. I will explain the system clearly on Day One.
- 🚻 There is often a **WC on board**, and we also plan regular comfort stops along the way.
- 🪜 **Mobility & boarding:** There are steps when getting on and off the coach, so please take your time and use the handrail.
- 🛳️ This tour includes **ferry crossings** between Britain and Ireland, so it helps to keep a layer and anything essential in your day bag rather than packed in your suitcase.
- 🥪 **Snacks are absolutely fine.** For general comfort and safety on a moving vehicle, it's best to avoid hot food and hot drinks while on the coach.
- 🎒 Bring a **small day bag** with what you may need during the day. Main suitcases stay in the coach hold until hotel arrival on travel days.
- 💼 **Carry-on space on the coach is limited.** Smaller soft bags such as backpacks or tote-style bags work best overhead or under the seat. Wheel-based carry-on suitcases usually do not fit well in the racks above. They are best avoided as on-board bags.
- 🔔 **Seatbelts are required by law** while the coach is moving.
- 🧼 Please be mindful of **general hygiene**. Clean hands and common sense go a long way in shared spaces. If you feel unwell, wear a mask and keep some distance where appropriate.

🌦️ What to expect from the weather

Weather across Britain and Ireland can shift between regions and within a few hours. Forecasts are useful, but flexibility helps most.

🌤️ A practical reality

You might get a bit of everything in one day, which is fairly normal here. A couple of flexible layers will usually serve you better than worrying too much about the forecast.

🧭 What usually helps

Treat forecasts as a guide rather than a guarantee, and expect occasional changes to pace or stop timing when conditions shift.

But honestly — don't let the forecast worry you too much. We adapt to whatever comes our way, and some of the best moments happen in between the raindrops.

🥃 "Today's rain is tomorrow's whisky."
– A local favourite in both Scotland and Ireland

🎒 What to pack

Most people find they pack more than they actually use. Comfortable, practical and easy to manage tends to win every time on this tour.

Essentials

- 👟 Comfortable walking shoes
- 🧥 Layered clothing for changing conditions
- ☔ A waterproof jacket
- 🎒 A small day bag
- 🔌 A UK Type G plug adapter (three rectangular prongs) View plug type
- 🎧 Optional: wired headphones with a 3.5mm jack to use with our walking-tour audio devices

Packing smarter

- 💼 Think practical rather than "just in case" — and leave a little room for things you pick up along the way.
- 👜 During the day: Think about what you are likely to need — and equally what you probably will not. It is never much fun having medication buried at the bottom of your suitcase on a travel day, or carrying more around than you need.
- 💧 Optional: bring a reusable drink bottle, but avoid bulky bottles — collapsible or slim styles are easiest to carry on coach days.
- 💡 Good shoes and a waterproof jacket you trust will do most of the heavy lifting on this tour.

🎒 **Luggage allowance:** 1 suitcase (max 23kg / 50lbs) plus 1 soft hand-luggage bag. The hand-luggage bag should be soft-sided (backpack/tote style), without wheels or a telescopic handle. Please label your bags clearly before arrival and pack so you can handle your own luggage for short distances when needed.

🧺 Laundry facilities can vary by hotel and timing, and may not be practical on this tour. It is best to plan as if you will not have laundry access.

📲 Staying connected on tour

I use WhatsApp for reminders and day-to-day updates while we are travelling. It works alongside your official documents and welcome email, and it usually works well over hotel or café Wi-Fi.

1. Download WhatsApp before you travel if you do not already use it — either from the link below or directly from your phone's app store.
   Download WhatsApp here
2. Set up your profile and verify your number.
3. Save my number in your phone from the welcome email or with the links above.
4. If you use WhatsApp, feel free to send me a quick message once you are set up. If not, no problem at all — you will still receive all key details.

👫 **Travelling with someone?** It helps if both of you message me, just in case phones get separated during the trip.

Most hotels and many public places offer free Wi-Fi. If you plan to rely on mobile data, it is worth checking roaming options with your provider before travel. Some people choose to use an eSIM as a simple alternative for staying connected across multiple countries.

💼 Practical notes

A few practical notes that tend to come up — worth a quick read before you travel.

🚦 A highlights-style itinerary

This is a fast-moving journey covering multiple regions and countries. Some days involve early starts or longer travel distances, balanced by rewarding experiences along the way.

🚶 Walking

Expect uneven streets, stairs, city walking and days where comfortable shoes matter more than style points.

🏨 Hotel styles vary

Across Britain and Ireland we stay in a mix of modern and historic properties. Room sizes, layouts and facilities can differ from what people may be used to elsewhere.

🍽️ Included meals

Breakfast is included daily and some dinners are provided. On included meal days, timings are set to keep the itinerary running smoothly, so punctuality is appreciated.

👥 Travelling as a group

Touring as a group works best when everyone is mindful of shared timings — I will make sure things run smoothly from my end.

👮 Your Driver

Your Driver plays a key role in both the safety and smooth running of each day. Driving hours are legally regulated, so it helps everyone if we are ready to depart at the agreed time.

💳 Money & payments

Card payments are widely accepted throughout the UK and Ireland, though carrying a small amount of cash is still useful — especially at stops where cards may not be accepted, and for gratuities such as Local Specialists who join us for sightseeing.

The simplest option is usually to withdraw a small amount from an ATM/cash machine, as exchange counters are limited outside major airports and often charge higher rates or commission.

Optional experiences can be paid by card or cash.

💶 Gratuities

Some gratuities are included in your tour price — restaurant staff and hotel porters, for example. Tips for your Travel Director and Driver are separate unless pre-paid.

If you have pre-paid — thank you, it is genuinely appreciated.

Guidance on appropriate amounts is in your Trafalgar documents — or just ask me on tour.

If you are unsure whether gratuities are pre-paid, check your tour voucher or booking confirmation. It can still help to carry a little cash for day-to-day convenience.

💷 Currency

Ireland uses the Euro (€). The UK, including Northern Ireland, Scotland and Wales, uses Pounds Sterling (£).

🚻 Toilets

Some public facilities may require coins or small payment, so keeping a little cash handy can occasionally help.

🔒 Security

Keep passports, cards and valuables secure. Pickpocketing is not common, but just stay aware of your belongings in busy spots.

⭐ Optional experiences

Your tour already includes a lot — but optionals are worth knowing about. These are experiences that go a little deeper in certain places. Convenient, good value, and everything is organised for you.

These are not generic extras — they are hand-picked experiences that suit the pace and places of this particular tour. Many people who do them wish they had booked more.

Optional experiences are priced separately so people who want them can choose them, and people who prefer a quieter pace are not paying for something they would not use.
I will walk you through what is available once we are underway. There is never any pressure.

☎️ Important contact details

Save these before you travel — they are harder to find when you are already on the move.

Joel Plunkett

📱 **Phone / WhatsApp**
+44 7496 055 950

📧 **Email**
joelrplunkett@gmail.com

📸 **Instagram**
@tourwithjoel

🌍 **Website**
tourwithjoel.com

💾 **Add to contacts**
Add Joel to contacts

Questions before the tour?

Before we meet, European Guest Services are your main point of contact for anything urgent or time-sensitive — they are set up to help and available during office hours. I will have my phone with me and will read messages when I can, but I am usually travelling or finishing up another tour before we meet. Anything that can wait, I will pick up once we are underway.

🚨 **Urgent or time-sensitive before departure?**
For anything that needs immediate attention before departure from London, please contact European Guest Services using the details below.

📞 **European Guest Services**
+44 207 620 8900

📧 **Email**
EuropeanGuestServices@ttc.com

💾 **Add to contacts**
Add European Guest Services to contacts

For peace of mind, save my number and European Guest Services now, and keep your official joining instructions somewhere easy to find before departure.

✨ **Final note**

During the tour, if you are ever unsure about anything, just ask. There is very little I have not come across before.

🇬🇧 See you in London.

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A personal guide from your Travel Director. For official timings, inclusions and operational details before the tour, refer to your Trafalgar documents.